

FORMAL ACCESSIBILITY AUDIT

Paving the Way to Fewer Potholes

Colorado Springs ArcGIS StoryMap

STANDARD

WCAG 2.1 Level AA

REGULATORY BASIS

ADA Title II — 28 CFR Part 35 (DOJ web/mobile rule)

AUDIT DATE

May 21, 2026

SCOPE

Automated DOM inspection and visual review

1. Executive Summary

The *Paving the Way to Fewer Potholes* StoryMap is a well-built, visually engaging public communication tool, and it already does several things right from an accessibility standpoint: it declares a page language, provides a skip-to-content link, uses proper landmark structure, labels most of its controls, and gives meaningful alt text to the majority of its images. That is a stronger starting point than most public-sector pages we review.

There are, however, a number of issues that should be remediated before the site can be considered conformant to WCAG 2.1 Level AA. The most significant are tied to the videos (captions are not actually wired up) and to several controls and links that are missing accessible names. None of these are difficult to fix, and addressing them carries a meaningful side benefit: the same work that makes the page accessible — captions, transcripts, descriptive link text, clean heading structure — also makes it substantially more discoverable to search engines.

2. Regulatory Context

Under Title II of the Americans with Disabilities Act, state and local government web content and mobile applications must conform to **WCAG 2.1 Level AA**. The U.S. Department of Justice finalized this technical standard in its 2024 rule and, in an interim final rule issued in April 2026, extended the original compliance dates by one year while leaving the substantive requirements unchanged.

Because Colorado Springs and El Paso County each serve a population well above 50,000, the operative compliance deadline for this content is **April 26, 2027**. The rule applies not only to content the entity builds directly but also to content delivered on its behalf through third-party platforms and vendors — which includes the StoryMap host, the embedded dashboard, and any mobile reporting app offered as a public service. Vendor-delivered content does not transfer the obligation away from the public entity.

3. Critical Findings

These represent likely Level A failures and should be treated as the first priority.

CRITICAL 3.1 — Videos lack functional captions (WCAG 1.2.2, Level A).

Both videos include a captions track element, but the track has no source file attached, so no captions are actually delivered. Combined with audio that plays through a custom player, this means deaf and hard-of-hearing users cannot access the video content. **Remediation:** attach a valid .vtt caption file to each video and confirm captions render in the player.

CRITICAL 3.2 — Custom video controls without a native fallback (WCAG 2.1.1, Level A).

Both video elements disable the native control set in favor of a custom control bar whose keyboard operability and labeling cannot be confirmed; the mute and fullscreen controls appear to be icon-only with no accessible name. **Remediation:** either restore the native controls attribute or ensure every custom control is keyboard-operable and carries a descriptive `aria-label`.

CRITICAL 3.3 — Empty heading element (WCAG 1.3.1, Level A).

An `<h3>` exists in the document with no text content, which disrupts heading-based navigation for screen reader users. **Remediation:** remove the empty heading or give it meaningful content.

4. Serious Findings

These should be remediated as a second priority.

SERIOUS 4.1 — Non-descriptive link text (WCAG 2.4.4 / 2.4.6).

Two separate links both read simply “Open link,” and both point to the GOCOS! reporting portal. Users navigating by link list cannot tell what either link does. **Remediation:** use descriptive text such as “Report a pothole using the GOCOS! app,” or add an equivalent `aria-label`.

SERIOUS 4.2 — Header buttons without accessible names (WCAG 4.1.2, Level A).

The “Share” and “More actions” buttons rely on icon spans marked `aria-hidden`, leaving the buttons without a reliable accessible name in some assistive technology. **Remediation:** add `aria-label` directly to each button.

SERIOUS 4.3 — Close buttons without context (WCAG 4.1.2, Level A).

Several “Close” buttons lack an `aria-label` indicating what they close. **Remediation:** label each, e.g., `aria-label="Close dialog"`.

SERIOUS 4.4 — Non-sequential, misused heading hierarchy (WCAG 1.3.1, Level A).

Heading levels skip and are used for visual styling rather than document structure — for example, a phone number is marked as an `<h2>`, and body-text calls to action are marked as headings. **Remediation:** restructure to a logical, nested outline (H1 → H2 → H3) and reserve heading tags for genuine section titles.

SERIOUS 4.5 — Informational image with empty alt text (WCAG 1.1.1, Level A).

One content image carries an empty `alt` attribute without being explicitly marked decorative. **Remediation:** supply meaningful alt text if informational, or mark it decorative if not.

SERIOUS 4.6 — Interaction barrier on embedded content (WCAG 2.1.1, Level A).

The embedded Power BI dashboard requires an “Enable interaction” step that may trap or block keyboard focus, and the embedded map presents similar risk. **Remediation:** confirm the enable control is keyboard-reachable, that focus enters and exits the `iframe` cleanly, and provide a text-based alternative for the underlying dashboard data.

5. Moderate Findings

Best-practice and AA-supporting items to address as capacity allows.

MODERATE 5.1 — Truncated navigation without disclosure (WCAG 2.4.3).

The top navigation overflows and hides items behind a scroll arrow; keyboard users may not realize additional items exist. **Remediation:** ensure all items are reachable and announce the presence of hidden items.

MODERATE 5.2 — `role="application"` on video and map containers (WCAG 4.1.2).

This role suppresses standard assistive-technology keystrokes and shifts full keyboard implementation onto the author. **Remediation:** audit keyboard behavior inside these regions; prefer `role="region"` with a label unless full custom keyboard handling is genuinely needed.

MODERATE

5.3 — New-tab link without warning (WCAG 3.2.2, Level A).

The “Open live content in a new tab” link does not warn that a new window will open. **Remediation:** add a textual or `aria-label` cue indicating a new window.

MODERATE

5.4 — Decorative text marked as headings.

Several calls to action and body sentences are coded as headings, inflating the heading outline. **Remediation:** move these to paragraph or styled elements.

6. What Is Already Working

It is worth stating plainly what the build gets right, because it is a lot:

- ✓ The page sets `lang="en"`, and the page title is descriptive.
- ✓ A functional skip-to-content link is present.
- ✓ `main`, `nav`, `article`, and banner landmarks are all in place.
- ✓ The majority of images carry good alt text.
- ✓ Both videos have descriptive `aria-label` attributes, and the dashboard iframe has a detailed title.
- ✓ Icon-only “Previous/Next headings” and “Copy section link” buttons are labeled, and the return-to-top control has a full accessible name.

This is a solid foundation that makes the remaining remediation straightforward rather than structural.

7. Two Governance Recommendations on the Reporting Pathway

Beyond the technical findings above, two structural points about how residents report potholes deserve attention.

7.1 — A simple, accessible web form should be a first-class reporting option. The current reporting flow leans on the GOCOS! mobile app and a phone line. The app pathway, as a third-party mobile application offered as a public service, is itself subject to WCAG 2.1 AA and may not currently meet it. A plain, server-rendered web form — name, location, description, optional photo — that works without app installation, without JavaScript-heavy interaction, and with full keyboard and screen-reader support is the most reliable way to guarantee equal access. It should be offered alongside the app, not behind it.

7.2 — Do not make the mobile app the sole pathway, in part because of age restrictions. Mobile app store distribution commonly carries age gating and account-creation requirements that can exclude or complicate use by minors under 18, and a reporting service that effectively requires an app may leave younger residents and households without a usable channel. A simple web form and the existing phone line together ensure the service does not depend on a single age- or device-restricted route. This is both an accessibility and an equal-access concern.

8. Prioritized Remediation Roadmap

PRIORITY	ACTIONS
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Immediate (Critical)	Attach working .vtt caption files to both videos; confirm custom video controls are keyboard-operable and labeled; remove the empty heading.
High	Replace “Open link” text with descriptive names; restructure the heading hierarchy into a logical outline.
Medium	Label the Share, More actions, and Close buttons; audit the embedded dashboard for keyboard-focus issues and provide a data alternative; stand up or confirm a simple accessible web reporting form.
Lower	Address navigation truncation disclosure, role=“application” usage, the new-tab warning, and stylistic heading misuse.

9. A Note on the Captions-and-Transcripts Investment

The single highest-value fix here — adding captions and transcripts to the videos — is worth highlighting because it pays off twice. It resolves the most consequential accessibility failure on the page, and because search engines index caption and transcript text, it also makes the video content discoverable in a way that audio and video alone never are. Accessible media and search-visible media are, in practice, the same work.

10. Methodology and Limitation

This audit was conducted through automated DOM inspection and visual review. A complete assessment should be paired with manual testing using screen readers (NVDA, VoiceOver) and keyboard-only navigation, particularly for the embedded dashboard, the embedded map, and the custom video player, where interaction-level issues are best caught by hands-on testing. Automated review alone typically surfaces only a portion of real-world barriers.

Prepared as a WCAG 2.1 AA conformance review against ADA Title II requirements. This document is a technical accessibility assessment and not legal advice.